

The power of recognition: rethinking the instrumentality of status in world politics

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Accruing social status is important for states.¹ Status—here understood as collectively recognized standing within hierarchies—is a crucial element of international politics.² There are two key reasons for this. First, both representatives and citizens gain a sense of well-being and security from the knowledge that their state has higher status than others.³ Second, and perhaps more importantly, having high status means that states can oblige other states to act in ways they normally would not.⁴ Leaders and citizens believe that higher status bestows more power and influence upon their state.⁵ For instance, in the view of Jan Petersen, Norway's former minister of foreign affairs, the provision of Norwegian military support to Afghanistan increased its status, allowing it to harness future solidarity in challenging situations.⁶ Likewise, citizens of the United States believe that status

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¹ For reviews of this research field, see Allan Dafoe, Jonathan Renshon and Paul Huth, 'Reputation and status as motives for war', *Annual Review of Political Science*, vol. 17, 2014, pp. 371–93, <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-polisci-071112-213421>; Elias Götz, 'Status matters in world politics', *International Studies Review* 23: 1, 2021, pp. 228–47, <https://doi.org/10.1093/isr/viaa046>; Paul K. MacDonald and Joseph M. Parent, 'The status of status in world politics', *World Politics* 73: 2, 2021, pp. 358–91, <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0043887120000301>. 'Prestige' and 'status' are often used interchangeably. I use 'status' because, in contrast to 'prestige', it connotes *ranking* in a hierarchy and is more a function of social recognition. See Dafoe, Renshon and Huth, 'Reputation and status as motives for war', p. 376.

² Deborah Welch Larson, T.V. Paul and William C. Wohlforth, 'Status and world order', in T.V. Paul, Deborah Welch Larson and William C. Wohlforth, eds, *Status in world politics* (Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press, 2014), p. 7; Marina G. Duque, 'Recognizing international status: a relational approach', *International Studies Quarterly* 62: 3, 2018, pp. 577–92 at p. 578, <https://doi.org/10.1093/isq/sqy001>.

³ Benjamin de Carvalho and Iver B. Neumann, 'Introduction: small states and status', in Benjamin de Carvalho and Iver B. Neumann, eds, *Small state status seeking: Norway's quest for international standing* (Abingdon and New York: Routledge, 2015), p. 7; Erik Ringmar, *Identity, interest and action: a cultural explanation of Sweden's intervention in the Thirty Years War* (Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press, 1996), p. 3; Steven Ward, *Status and the challenge of rising powers* (Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press, 2017).

⁴ Dafoe, Renshon and Huth, 'Reputation and status as motives for war', p. 380; Larson, Paul and Wohlforth, 'Status and world order', pp. 7–8; Jonathan Mercer, 'The illusion of international prestige', *International Security* 41: 4, 2017, pp. 133–68 at pp. 136–7, https://doi.org/10.1162/ISEC_a_00276; Jonathan Renshon, *Fighting for status: hierarchy and conflict in world politics* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2017), p. 33.

⁵ Joslyn Barnhart, 'Humiliation and third-party aggression', *World Politics* 69: 3, 2017, pp. 532–68 at p. 539, <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0043887117000028>; Andrew Q. Greve and Jack S. Levy, 'Power transitions, status dissatisfaction, and war: the Sino-Japanese War of 1894–1895', *Security Studies* 27: 1, 2018, pp. 148–78 at pp. 167–72, <https://doi.org/10.1080/09636412.2017.1360078>.

⁶ Peter Viggo Jakobsen, Jens Ringsmose and Håkon Lunde Saxi, 'Prestige-seeking small states: Danish and Norwegian military contributions to US-led operations', *European Journal of International Security* 3: 2, 2018, pp. 256–77 at p. 269, <https://doi.org/10.1017/eis.2017.20>; William C. Wohlforth, Benjamin de Carvalho, Halvard Leira and Iver B. Neumann, 'Moral authority and status in International Relations: good states and

in world politics is valuable due to its instrumental benefits.⁷ Such instrumental benefits include, but are not limited to, privileges, decision-making power and a higher likelihood that other actors will defer to a state's wishes.⁸

But how is status converted into power in world politics? International Relations (IR) scholars have yet to identify and isolate the power that runs from status.⁹ Indeed, the only article thus far to investigate the relationship between status and power concludes that there is none.¹⁰ States face incentives to withhold recognition from other states; at least from competitors. After all, status is a hierarchical and competitive good.¹¹ As Larson and colleagues suggest: 'If everyone has high status, then no one does.'¹² Thus, states may be hesitant to recognize other states in ways that could increase their power.¹³ If no power runs from status, it follows that the benefits of recognition in the international sphere is limited to the intrinsic satisfaction of holding a status position.¹⁴

In this article I argue that status still has instrumental value, though not as previously conceived. IR scholars often claim that states with lower status are more likely to voluntarily defer to higher-status states.¹⁵ Instead, a better way of approaching the power of status is to explore what states actively do with their high status. I propose a 'Gestalt switch' where *recognition* converts status into power. In this theoretical framework, status works in much the same way as other power resources. For example, wealthy and militarily capable states leverage their money and military assistance to make other states more wealthy and secure. They offer trade deals, development aid or military assurances. In return, the wealthy and powerful states gain partners, trust and privileges. Status works in the same way. High-status states can offer more recognition than other states. This prospec-

the social dimension of status seeking', *Review of International Studies* 44: 3, 2018, pp. 526–46 at pp. 539–40, <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0260210517000560>.

⁷ Ryan Powers and Jonathan Renshon, 'International status concerns and domestic support for political leaders', *American Journal of Political Science* 67: 3, 2023, pp. 732–47, <https://doi.org/10.1111/ajps.12689>.

⁸ Pål Røren, 'On the social status of the European Union', *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies* 58: 3, 2020, pp. 706–22 at p. 709, <https://doi.org/10.1111/jcms.12962>; Dafeo, Renshon and Huth, 'Reputation and status as motives for war', p. 373; Larson, Paul and Wohlforth, 'Status and world order', pp. 7–8; Mercer, 'The illusion of international prestige', pp. 136–7; Renshon, *Fighting for status*, p. 33.

⁹ Ward, *Status and the challenge of rising powers*, p. 36.

¹⁰ Mercer, 'The illusion of international prestige'.

¹¹ Larson, Paul and Wohlforth, 'Status and world order', p. 9; Greve and Levy, 'Power transitions, status dissatisfaction, and war', p. 8; William C. Wohlforth, 'Unipolarity, status competition, and great power war', *World Politics* 61: 1, 2009, pp. 28–57 at p. 30, <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0043887109000021>.

¹² Larson, Paul and Wohlforth, 'Status and world order', p. 9.

¹³ Mercer, 'The illusion of international prestige', pp. 141–2.

¹⁴ However, status can still produce domestic effects: Ward, *Status and the challenge of rising powers*; Steven Ward, 'Status, stratified rights, and accommodation in International Relations', *Journal of Global Security Studies* 5: 1, 2020, pp. 160–78, <https://doi.org/10.1093/jogss/ogz014>; Paul David Beaumont, *The grammar of status competition: international hierarchies and domestic politics* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2024); Carsten-Andreas Schulz and Cameron G. Thies, 'Status cues and normative change: how the Academy Awards facilitated Chile's gender identity law', *Review of International Studies* 50: 1, 2024, pp. 127–45, <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0260210522000626>; Paul Beaumont, 'Brexit, Retrotopia and the perils of post-colonial delusions', *Global Affairs* 3: 4–5, 2017, pp. 379–90, <https://doi.org/10.1080/23340460.2018.1478674>.

¹⁵ Renshon, *Fighting for status*, p. 42; Reinhard Wolf, 'Taking interaction seriously: asymmetrical roles and the behavioral foundations of status', *European Journal of International Relations* 25: 4, 2019, pp. 1186–1211 at p. 1195, <https://doi.org/10.1177/1354066119837338>; Yuen Foong Khong, 'Power as prestige in world politics', *International Affairs* 95: 1, 2019, pp. 119–42 at p. 120, <https://doi.org/10.1093/ia/iiy245>; Götz, 'Status matters in world politics', p. 230.

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tive recognition makes states more willing to act in accordance with the wishes of the high-status state. Recognition thus becomes the mechanism through which actors convert their status into power.

To show the utility of this theoretical framework, I analyse how the United States uses recognition to convert its status into power. A plausibility probe shows that the US can use recognition to influence the actions of lower-status states to its own benefit. For example, the Nordic states participated in US-led military coalitions where they had no direct interest in the outcome of the conflict. Moreover, rising powers also seek status in a way that is beneficial to the US.¹⁶ But the effectiveness of recognition decreases once the status gap between recognizer and recognized shrinks. Rising powers like Russia are cautious not to appear deferential. This leads to more creative and competitive approaches to status-seeking, that do not benefit the US.

This article proceeds in five stages. I first review the literature on status and show that while scholars often assume that status brings states more power, there is little evidence to support this claim. Second, I develop a theoretical framework that explains how high-status states use recognition to incentivize beneficiary actions from others. Third, I outline the research design and explain why the US' relationships with both small power allies and rival major powers work as a plausibility probe to explore how recognition converts status into power. Fourth, I carry out this analysis, showing how US recognition motivates state behaviour across different contexts and identifying the conditions under which recognition succeeds or fails as a mechanism of power. Fifth, I conclude by discussing the article's implications for the study of status, recognition and power in international politics.

Why do states seek status? A survey of the literature

The study of status and prestige in IR has become an established research agenda.¹⁷ The wave of research that emerged during the early 2000s centred particularly on status as a motivation for a wide variety of behaviours.¹⁸ Most of this research argues that states seek status for two reasons. First, humans have an 'intrinsic stake

¹⁶ In this article, I define rising powers as 'states intent on gaining recognition as a great power and recognized as such by their contemporaries': Richard Ned Lebow, *Why nations fight: past and future motives for war* (Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press, 2010), p. 101.

¹⁷ Seminal pieces within this strand include Paul, Larson and Wohlforth, *Status in world politics*; Reinhard Wolf, 'Respect and disrespect in international politics: the significance of status recognition', *International Theory* 3: 1, 2011, pp. 105–42, <https://doi.org/10.1017/S1752971910000308>; Yong Deng, *China's struggle for status: the realignment of International Relations* (Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press, 2008); Duque, 'Recognizing international status'; Michelle Murray, *The struggle for recognition in International Relations: status, revisionism, and rising powers* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2018); Ward, *Status and the challenge of rising powers*.

¹⁸ See, for example, Andrej Krickovic and Yuval Weber, 'What can Russia teach us about change? Status-seeking as a catalyst for transformation in international politics', *International Studies Review* 20: 2, 2018, pp. 292–300, <https://doi.org/10.1093/isr/viyo24>; Deborah Welch Larson and Alexei Shevchenko, 'Status seekers: Chinese and Russian responses to U.S. primacy', *International Security* 34: 4, 2010, pp. 63–95, <https://doi.org/10.1162/isec.2010.34.4.63>; Pål Røren, 'Status seeking in the friendly Nordic neighborhood', *Cooperation and Conflict* 54: 4, 2019, pp. 562–79, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0010836719828410>; Wohlforth et al., 'Moral authority and status in IR'.

into how their group, hence their state fares in relation to other groups'.¹⁹ In other words, seeking status is motivated by an autotelic 'good-in-itself'.²⁰ Second, scholars often contend that status produces positive by-products. These come in the form of visibility, influence and *voluntary deference* on the international stage.²¹ Here, status is instrumental. It becomes a 'means to an end', in that position in a status hierarchy generates power and clarifies 'who is expected to defer in a given situation'.²²

There is, however, little evidence that status generates power in world politics.²³ Indeed, the claim that status boosts power in world politics has never been demonstrated, making it 'no more than an assumption'.²⁴ In fact, the only work to test the assumption ultimately refutes it. Mercer shows that states might garner status from winning wars, but that it does not produce voluntary deference.²⁵ Even those most likely to defer—friends and allies—are hesitant to do so. Thus, if states are only pursuing status for its intrinsic value, then—according to Mercer—status is an illusion.²⁶ Likewise, MacDonald and Parent's 2021 review points out that no work to date has captured voluntary deference stemming from status.²⁷ And if states do not defer to other high status states, the authors suggest, 'then the pursuit of status itself may be a chimera'.²⁸

This critique on the part of Mercer and MacDonald and Parent is exaggerated. Status is meaningful even if it does not elicit voluntary deference from international actors. Status is important for leaders, state representatives and citizens' senses of identity and self-esteem.²⁹ Moreover, international status dynamics have strong effects on domestic politics, public discourse and national pride.³⁰ However, Mercer's refutation of the instrumental benefits of status removes one

¹⁹ Tudor Onea, 'Immoderate greatness: is great power restraint a practical grand strategy?', *European Journal of International Security* 2: 1, 2017, pp. 111–32 at p. 129, <https://doi.org/10.1017/eis.2016.15>; see also Greve and Levy, 'Power transitions, status dissatisfaction, and war', p. 155.

²⁰ Larson, Paul and Wohlforth, 'Status and world order', p. 17; Larson and Shevchenko, 'Status seekers'; Deborah Welch Larson and Alexei Shevchenko, 'Russia says no: power, status, and emotions in foreign policy', *Communist and Post-Communist Studies* 47: 3–4, 2014, pp. 269–79, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.postcomstud.2014.09.003>; Wohlforth, 'Unipolarity, status competition, and great power war', p. 29. There are also those who show that status produces or is contingent on domestic effects and affairs; see Ward, *Status and the challenge of rising powers*; Beaumont, *The grammar of status competition*; Schulz and Thies, 'Status cues and normative change'.

²¹ Dafoe, Renshon and Huth, 'Reputation and status as motives for war', p. 373; Larson, Paul and Wohlforth, 'Status and world order', pp. 7–8; Mercer, 'The illusion of international prestige', pp. 136–7; Renshon, *Fighting for status*, p. 33.

²² Røren, 'On the social status of the European Union', p. 709.

²³ Barnhart, 'Humiliation and third-party aggression', p. 539; Dafoe, Renshon and Huth, 'Reputation and status as motives for war', p. 382; Tuomas Forsberg, Regina Heller and Reinhard Wolf, 'Introduction', *Communist and Post-Communist Studies* 47: 3–4, 2014, pp. 261–8 at p. 264, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.postcomstud.2014.09.007>.

²⁴ Ward, *Status and the challenge of rising powers*, p. 36.

²⁵ Mercer, 'The illusion of international prestige'.

²⁶ Mercer, 'The illusion of international prestige', pp. 134–5.

²⁷ MacDonald and Parent, 'The status of status in world politics'.

²⁸ MacDonald and Parent, 'The status of status in world politics', p. 369.

²⁹ Ward, *Status and the challenge of rising powers*; Anne L. Clunan, 'Historical aspirations and the domestic politics of Russia's pursuit of international status', *Communist and Post-Communist Studies* 47: 3–4, 2014, pp. 281–90, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.postcomstud.2014.09.002>; Nina Wilén, 'From "peacekept" to peacekeeper: seeking international status by narrating new identities', *Journal of Global Security Studies* 7: 1, 2022, <https://doi.org/10.1093/jogss/ogabo30>; Beaumont, 'Brexit, Retrotopia and the perils of post-colonial delusions'.

³⁰ Ward, *Status and the challenge of rising powers*; Beaumont, *The grammar of status competition*; Schulz and Thies, 'Status cues and normative change'.

of the primary motivations for states to seek status and for scholars to study those states. As such, the critique poses a serious challenge to the literature.

Theoretical framework: rethinking the instrumentality of status

The usual story told in the literature on status in IR is that state A seeks status by pursuing recognition from states B, C and D by behaving in a certain way.³¹ This may include providing aid, diplomatic mediation or going to war.³² State A is then collectively recognized for its effort. This recognition leads to a rise in their social status.³³ In turn, increased social status brings more power. The power is assumed dormant, often expressed as voluntary deference to the higher-status actor's wishes.³⁴

This conceptualization generates major methodological and analytical challenges. First, it is unclear when and how actors will defer to higher-status states. Such deference is also difficult to spot and to isolate from other effects. We might assume that high-status states are more likely over time to get their way compared to states with lower status.³⁵ However, many other factors can influence power, making it hard to isolate the specific effect of status. Second, using voluntary deference as evidence sets an unrealistically high bar for demonstrating the instrumental value of status. In Mercer's view, status is illusory because states did not defer to the British empire after the Second Boer War.³⁶ But just because the United Kingdom failed to elicit deference does not mean that status cannot produce instrumental effects.³⁷ Influence, authority, privileges and access are subcategories of power that link to status.³⁸ Yet, even these forms of influence do not satisfy the unreasonably high empirical threshold that requires clear-cut instances of one state deferring outright to another's preferences.

There is an alternative way to capture the power of status: instead of looking at the dormant power that it has, it is possible to focus on the power that runs from the very act of recognition. Extant literature on status in IR has alluded to this phenomenon, but have rarely expanded upon the fact that states seek and 'achieve status through making themselves useful to great powers'.³⁹ These scholars allude

³¹ Larson, Paul and Wohlforth, 'Status and world order', pp. 10–12.

³² In contrast, see Matthew Crandall and Mari-Liis Sulg, 'Small states and new status opportunities: Estonia's foreign policy towards Africa', *European Politics and Society* 24: 2, 2023, pp. 250–64, <https://doi.org/10.1080/23745118.2021.1990662>; Phil Baxter, Jenna Jordan and Lawrence Rubin, 'How small states acquire status: a social network analysis', *International Area Studies Review* 21: 3, 2018, pp. 191–213, <https://doi.org/10.1177/2233865918776844>; Renshon, *Fighting for status*.

³³ Pål Røren and Anders Wivel, 'King in the North: evaluating the status recognition and performance of the Scandinavian countries', *International Relations* 37: 2, 2023, pp. 298–323, <https://doi.org/10.1177/00471178221110135>.

³⁴ Larson, Paul and Wohlforth, 'Status and world order', p. 18; Wolf, 'Taking interaction seriously', pp. 1189–92.

³⁵ Dafoe, Renshon and Huth, 'Reputation and status as motives for war', p. 375; Larson, Paul and Wohlforth, 'Status and world order', pp. 18–19.

³⁶ Mercer, 'The illusion of international prestige', pp. 166–8.

³⁷ Ward, *Status and the challenge of rising powers*; Beaumont, *The grammar of status competition*, ch. 3.

³⁸ Barnhart, 'Humiliation and third-party aggression', p. 539; David A. Lake, *Hierarchy in International Relations* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 2011), pp. 165–74; Duque, 'Recognizing international status', pp. 580–1; Jakobsen, Ringsmose and Saxi, 'Prestige-seeking small states', pp. 263–70.

³⁹ de Carvalho and Neumann, 'Introduction', p. 2; for a similar take, see also Kristin M. Haugevik, 'Status, small states, and significant others: re-reading Norway's attraction to Britain in the twentieth century', in de

to the fact that great powers have useful helpers to do their bidding. But the analytical focus of this ‘first wave’ research on status is set mostly on how and why states *seek* status.⁴⁰

The proposed *Gestalt* switch of this article is that the power of status should instead be conceptualized as *actions driven by the prospect of recognition*. Recognition, in this context, involves conferring respect and acknowledgement for a state’s desired social standing.⁴¹ Status relies on recognition—after all, states cannot decide their own standing. The *intersubjectivity* of status means that states will struggle to obtain the recognition to secure their own status ambitions.⁴² They must convince other states—via actions or words—that they deserve the status to which they aspire.⁴³

In this relationship, those who recognize the status-seekers are in a position of power.⁴⁴ Specifically, status ‘yields control over social outcomes of value to others, namely, liking and respect’.⁴⁵ Actors want respect from higher-status actors. This means that high-status actors can wield social power over others.⁴⁶ In other words, these recognizing states can make other states act in ways that they normally would not, if recognition were not on the table.⁴⁷ The more the group of recognizers ‘consists of actors whose opinions matter, the greater the effects of backpatting and opprobrium’.⁴⁸

In this reversed framework, status works in a very similar way to other power resources. States with large, healthy economies attract investors from abroad, and military-capable states are indispensable allies. Thus, wealthy and military-capable states make other states more wealthy and secure by offering them trade agreements, development aid or military assurances. In return, the wealthy and powerful states gain partners, trust and legitimacy. Status works in the same way,

Carvalho and Neumann, eds, *Small state status seeking*, pp. 42–56; Nina Græger, ‘From “forces for good” to “forces for status”? Small state military status seeking’, in de Carvalho and Neumann, eds, *Small state status seeking*, pp. 86–107.

⁴⁰ Beaumont, *The grammar of status competition*, pp. 4–5.

⁴¹ Erik Ringmar, ‘The international politics of recognition’, in Thomas Lindemann and Erik Ringmar, eds, *The international politics of recognition* (Boulder, CO: Paradigm, 2012), pp. 6–8; Karl Gustafsson, ‘Recognising recognition through thick and thin: insights from Sino-Japanese relations’, *Cooperation and Conflict* 51: 3, 2016, pp. 255–71 at pp. 258–60, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0010836715610594>; Minda Holm and Ole Jacob Sending, ‘States before relations: on misrecognition and the bifurcated regime of sovereignty’, *Review of International Studies* 44: 5, 2018, pp. 829–47 at p. 830, <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0260210518000372>.

⁴² Murray, *The struggle for recognition in IR*, pp. 54–5.

⁴³ Thomas Forsberg, ‘Status conflicts between Russia and the West: perceptions and emotional biases’, *Communist and Post-Communist Studies* 47: 3–4, 2014, pp. 323–31 at pp. 324–6, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.postcomstud.2014.09.006>; Brian Rathbun, Nina Srinivasan Rathbun and Caleb Pomeroy, ‘No fair! Distinguishing between the pursuit of status and equity in International Relations’, *International Studies Quarterly* 66: 1, 2022, <https://doi.org/10.1093/isq/isqac002>.

⁴⁴ This dynamic relates to what Lake calls ‘symbolic obeisance’: costly acts of submission that acknowledge and affirm the authority of the ruler: Lake, *Hierarchy in IR*, pp. 165–74.

⁴⁵ Susan T. Fiske and Jennifer Berdahl, ‘Social power’, in Arie W. Kruglanski and E. Tory Higgins, *Social psychology: handbook of basic principles*, 2nd edn (New York: Guilford Press, 2007), pp. 678–92 at p. 682.

⁴⁶ Fiske and Berdahl, ‘Social power’, p. 682. Wolf, ‘Taking interaction seriously’, p. 1195.

⁴⁷ Daniel H. Nexon and Iver B. Neumann, ‘Hegemonic-order theory: a field-theoretic account’, *European Journal of International Relations* 24: 3, 2018, pp. 662–86 at p. 673, <https://doi.org/10.1177/1354066117716524>.

⁴⁸ Alastair Iain Johnston, ‘Treating international institutions as social environments’, *International Studies Quarterly* 45: 4, 2001, pp. 487–515 at p. 501, <https://doi.org/10.1111/0020-8833.00212>.

but instead of trade deals and military assurances, recognition is the mechanism that converts status into power.⁴⁹

The power of status can be initiated by either the recognizer or the status-seeker. For example, Donald Trump's push for NATO countries to meet the alliance's target of spending at least two per cent of their GDP on defence shows the strategic use of recognition. In his first presidential term, Trump intensified the rhetoric on burden-sharing.⁵⁰ Some countries, particularly the Baltic states, saw increased defence spending as a status-seeking move.⁵¹ After meeting the target, the Trump administration praised and recognized the Baltic states by inviting them to the White House, and creating an exclusive '2 percenters club'.⁵² The power of status also works indirectly; lower-status states might act to impress or help high-status states without direct incentives. For example, Wohlforth and colleagues suggest that small states compete against each other 'to be seen as complying with great power favoured norms in an especially salient fashion'.⁵³

Viewed within this framework, a range of evidence from IR has already documented the power of recognition in world politics. For example, scholars have explored how states are willing to adapt their foreign policy behaviour to be recognized by other states.⁵⁴ Similarly, experimental research has shown that citizens and representatives want their state to change behaviour in order to maximize international recognition.⁵⁵ Put simply, states act in ways that other states might appreciate in the hope that they will be recognized.

Three theoretical expectations arise from this framework. These are explored and demonstrated further in the case-study developed below. First, the power of recognition *increases with the size of the status gap between the status-seeker and the recognizer*.⁵⁶ Not all trade agreements and military assurances are of equal worth.

⁴⁹ This form of social power—that arises from status—also resembles soft power, in that neither form relies on coercion or threats to work. However, the core of soft power is 'when one country gets other countries to want what it wants' without relying on coercion and payments. See Joseph S. Nye, Jr, 'Soft power', *Foreign Policy*, no. 80, 1990, pp. 153–71 at p. 166. In contrast, seeking status does not require states to genuinely want what recognizing states want. Furthermore, high-status states offer recognition as payment to get others to do what they want. Lastly, soft power rests on culture, political values and moral authority. While status is built on these assets, it also rests on material capabilities (hard power).

⁵⁰ Leonard August Schuette, 'Why NATO survived Trump: the neglected role of Secretary-General Stoltenberg', *International Affairs* 97: 6, 2021, pp. 1863–81 at pp. 1870–1, <https://doi.org/10.1093/ia/iaab167>.

⁵¹ Andris Banka, 'Reclaiming a good ally status: Baltic coping strategies in the America First world', *European Security* 30: 2, 2021, pp. 159–77 at p. 165, <https://doi.org/10.1080/09662839.2020.1840361>.

⁵² Banka, 'Reclaiming a good ally status', p. 167.

⁵³ Wohlforth et al., 'Moral authority and status in IR', p. 532.

⁵⁴ De Carvalho and Neumann, 'Introduction'; Banka, 'Reclaiming a good ally status'; Muhammet Koçak and Musa Akgül, 'Quest for regional power status: explaining Turkey's assertive foreign policy', *International Journal* 77: 2, 2022, pp. 292–312, <https://doi.org/10.1177/00207020221130310>; Deborah Welch Larson and Alexei Shevchenko, *Quest for status: Chinese and Russian foreign policy* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2019); Murray, *The struggle for recognition in IR*.

⁵⁵ Filip Viskupič, 'More valuable than blood and treasure? Experimental evidence on the impact of status on domestic preferences for military intervention', *Peace Economics, Peace Science and Public Policy* 26: 4, 2020, <https://doi.org/10.1515/peps-2020-0017>; Jonathan Renshon, 'Losing face and sinking costs: experimental evidence on the judgment of political and military leaders', *International Organization* 69: 3, 2015, pp. 659–95, <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0020818315000107>; Powers and Renshon, 'International status concerns and domestic support for political leaders'.

⁵⁶ Renshon, *Fighting for status*, p. 126; Evelyn Goh, 'Hierarchy and the role of the United States in the east Asian security order', *International Relations of the Asia-Pacific* 8: 3, 2008, pp. 353–77 at pp. 360–1, <https://doi.org/10.1093/irap/lcn011>; Wohlforth et al., 'Moral authority and status in IR', pp. 530–2; Pål Røren, 'The

On average, a trade deal with China matters more than a trade deal with Malta. Likewise, military assurances by major powers matter more to small powers than they do to other major powers. The bigger the gap in capabilities, the more a smaller state values these bilateral deals. Just as the power of trade deals and military assurances arises from the type of economy and military capabilities of the origin state, so too does the social status of a state determine the value of recognition.⁵⁷ Status-seekers often target the top of the hierarchy. For example, Norway sought status from the UK in the early twentieth century because the latter was the primary great power.⁵⁸ However, Norway shifted to seeking status from the US and Germany after the decline in the UK's status during the Cold War.⁵⁹

The second expectation is that the power of recognition depends not only on the position, but also on the *agency* and *skill* of the recognizer. High-status states might refuse to recognize status-seeking acts. This can occur when there is a shift in what is considered prestigious, or when new governments with different priorities assume power. This could hamper future beneficial status-seeking from smaller states. At the same time, over-recognition dilutes value. To be sure, in the short term the recognizing state would have more states doing its bidding. Yet this behaviour stops once the status-seeking state realizes that practically everyone receives recognition. Also, states cannot withhold recognition for too long. Recognizers might feel tempted to hold back recognition, hoping that the status-seeker will do even more to receive it. This might leave the status-seeker disenchanted and frustrated. Or—even worse—it might become hostile towards the high-status state.⁶⁰ Furthermore, states might recognize the status-seeker for something it has done or said, but the recognition might clash with what the status-seeker sees as a meaningful act of recognition. This leads to cases of misrecognition.⁶¹

Third, *recognition can be costly*. Some forms of recognition may involve little to no effort on the part of the recognizer. A verbal acknowledgement, or a state meeting or dinner, are inexpensive acts. In contrast, backing down, admitting wrongdoings or admitting states into a 'club' or international organization are more costly forms of recognition. Moreover, recognition may interfere with other foreign policy priorities.⁶² States might experience positional anxiety due to concerns that competitors will surpass them. Finally, actors may hesitate or refrain from recognizing if there is a perceived ideational cost of doing so. Actors often rely on conspicuous consumption or performances to enter a club or rise within its hierarchy.⁶³ However, sometimes entrance or ascendance cannot be achieved

belligerent bear: Russia, status orders, and war', *International Security* 47: 4, 2023, pp. 7–49 at p. 23, https://doi.org/10.1162/isec_a_00458.

⁵⁷ Ringmar, *Identity, interest and action*, p. 81.

⁵⁸ Haugevik, 'Status, small states, and significant others'.

⁵⁹ Haugevik, 'Status, small states, and significant others', p. 52.

⁶⁰ Steven Ward, 'Race, status, and Japanese revisionism in the early 1930s', *Security Studies* 22: 4, 2013, pp. 607–39, <https://doi.org/10.1080/09636412.2013.844517>.

⁶¹ Wolf, 'Respect and disrespect in international politics'; Gustafsson, 'Recognising recognition through thick and thin'.

⁶² This argument builds on Ward, 'Status, stratified rights, and accommodation in IR', pp. 166–70.

⁶³ Lilach Gilady, *The price of prestige: conspicuous consumption in International Relations* (Chicago: University of

by consumption. For example, diplomats face racialized and gendered barriers in various diplomatic ‘pecking orders’.⁶⁴ Likewise, during the nineteenth century China and Japan sought status as ‘civilized’ by transforming their domestic systems. But neither were recognized, due to the racism that underpinned the status order of international society at that time.⁶⁵ In more recent years, democratic high-status states have had an easier time recognizing other democratic small states. As Duque puts it, ‘similarity begets recognition’.⁶⁶ In contrast, a liberal democracy may withhold recognition of an autocracy, because doing so may inadvertently help legitimize a government structure they oppose.

In sum, the theoretical framework challenges conventional views of how status leads to power. It advocates analyses of recognition as an exercise of power. This reconceptualization suggests that status, via recognition, influences state behaviour. In the following section I build a case-study to demonstrate the usefulness of the theoretical framework.

Research design

In the remainder of this article I use the United States’ relationship with Russia and the Nordic states as a plausibility probe to explore and demonstrate how the power of recognition has been used in international politics. Plausibility probes are invoked to determine whether a theory holds in face of empirical scrutiny;⁶⁷ in doing so, researchers intentionally select cases that fit their theory. If the theory provides plausible explanations for phenomena, it warrants further testing.

Three reasons deduced from the framework above make this case a good plausibility probe. First, states will seek status from the US more than from any other state. States—whether big or small—normally seek status from those above them in status hierarchies: it matters more for states to receive an embassy, a state visit or verbal recognition from a high-status state than from a lower-status state.⁶⁸ If we apply the most common proxy for international status recognition, we see that the US has led the status hierarchy for almost 50 years (table 1). Thus, high-status states like the US receive bids for recognition from both major powers and smaller powers.

Chicago Press, 2018); Tristen Naylor, ‘The production and performance of status: behind the scenes of an international summit’, *Cooperation and Conflict* 60: 1, 2024, pp. 97–119, <https://doi.org/10.1177/00108367241261482>.

⁶⁴ Catriona Standfield, ‘Who gets to be a virtuoso? Diplomatic competence through an intersectional lens’, *The Hague Journal of Diplomacy* 17: 3, 2022, pp. 371–401 at p. 372, <https://doi.org/10.1163/1871191X-bja10112>.

⁶⁵ Tristen Naylor, *Social closure and international society: status groups from the family of civilised nations to the G20* (Abingdon and New York: Routledge, 2018), pp. 60–1; Tomoko T. Okagaki, *The logic of conformity: Japan’s entry into international society* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2013), p. 41.

⁶⁶ Duque, ‘Recognizing international status’, p. 588; also see Røren, ‘Status seeking in the friendly Nordic neighborhood’; Haugevik, ‘Status, small states, and significant others’.

⁶⁷ Harry Eckstein, *Regarding politics: essays on political theory, stability, and change* (Berkeley, CA: University of California Press, 1992), pp. 147–8; Jack S. Levy, ‘Case studies: types, designs, and logics of inference’, *Conflict Management and Peace Science* 25: 1, 2008, pp. 1–18 at pp. 6–7, <https://doi.org/10.1080/07388940701860318>.

⁶⁸ Renshon, *Fighting for status*, p. 126; Matt Malis and Alastair Smith, ‘State visits and leader survival’, *American Journal of Political Science* 65: 1, 2021, pp. 241–56 at pp. 243–5, <https://doi.org/10.1111/ajps.12520>; Erik Goldstein, ‘The politics of the state visit’, *The Hague Journal of Diplomacy* 3: 2, 2008, pp. 153–78 at p. 170, <https://doi.org/10.1163/187119108X323646>.

Table 1: Status ranking of selected states 1968–2021 (world ranking on PageRank score)

Year	US	Russia	China	Brazil	Norway	Denmark
1968	1	6	34	14	42	33
1978	2	6	11	19	65	50
1988	1	6	7	18	71	54
1998	1	6	7	15	68	44
2003	1	7	4	17	63	39
2008	1	8	4	14	61	49
2013	1	9	3	10	56	54
2014	1	9	3	14	51	47
2019	1	11	7	10	37	35
2021	1	12	5	13	40	43

Source: Birgitta Niklasson and Ann E. Towns, 'Diplomatic gender patterns and symbolic status signaling: introducing the GenDip dataset on gender and diplomatic representation', *International Studies Quarterly* 67: 4, 2023, <https://doi.org/10.1093/isq/sqado89>.

Note: PageRank is an algorithm originally developed by Google to rank websites. In this context sites and links are replaced by states and embassies. The assumption is here that establishing and maintaining embassies is a costly, strategic decision that signals recognition of a country's importance. PageRank measures a state's diplomatic recognition by considering both the number of embassies it receives and the status of the sending countries. It assigns more weight to ties from highly connected or prestigious states and fewer ties overall, iteratively calculating each state's centrality until the scores stabilize, resulting in a proxy for status recognition. For application and further explanation of the measure, see Jonathan Renshon, *Fighting for status: hierarchy and conflict in world politics* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2017), pp. 116–49.

Second, recognition from high-status states is in high demand. States that lead status hierarchies can increase the price status-seekers have to pay to obtain recognition. If multiple states seek status from the same state, they will need to stand out to be recognized. 'Standing out' often means doing more than what is expected or in some way outcompeting or outshining rival status-seekers.⁶⁹ In addition, when there is a bidding war, prices increase. Thus we can expect that states are more eager and conspicuous in their efforts to gain recognition from the US compared to other states.

Third, the US case also allows us to see the limits of recognition. The case selection logic of the article builds on Duque's finding that similar states tend to recognize each other.⁷⁰ We would expect not only that the Nordic states would seek status from the US, but that the US would have a low threshold for recognizing acts that are beneficial to it. These states are not only liberal democratic

⁶⁹ De Carvalho and Neumann, 'Introduction'; Røren, 'Status seeking in the friendly Nordic neighborhood'.

⁷⁰ Duque, 'Recognizing international status'.

states but are also longstanding allies. In contrast, as a unipolar power, the US has interests in almost every corner of the world and across most policy issues. The breadth of policy interests makes it more likely that recognition at times will be at odds with national interests.⁷¹ This particularly applies to situations where the US is both the recognizer and rival,⁷² and even more so when the US and other countries have different types of government and economic systems, or different foreign policy priorities. This is particularly true in the US–Russia relationship.

The following analysis is a case-study that foregrounds a status dynamic that has hitherto been latent in the extensive research on status-seeking in IR. The underlying logic here, based on the framework as constructed above, is that extant research on status has been attentive to what the status-seekers must do or acquire to gain recognition and status. Some scholars have even alluded to the idea that lower-status states want to be useful to higher-status states.⁷³ Thus, the analysis below starts from those acts of status-seeking—as shown in the existing status literature—and recasts them as demonstrations of how recognition converts status into power. To be sure, not all actions described in the literature are exclusively driven by status concerns. Status-seeking is often done with more than one goal in sight. To their credit, scholars have developed sound methodological approaches to isolate status concerns from other explanations. But it is hard, if not impossible, to venture into the minds of state leaders or representatives (let alone states themselves) and discern what has motivated a certain foreign policy. In cases where it is unclear whether a particular action was motivated by status, I supplement the academic literature with other sources, ranging from government documents to political statements and reports. Regardless, the analysis cannot say for certain that recognition was the primary goal of a particular action. Nor can it suggest that recognition was the sole mechanism that converted status to power. Instead, the aim for the case-study below is to explore instances, events or behaviour that plausibly stem from the pursuit of recognition and status.

Analysing the power of recognition

To put this analytical framework to use, the remainder of this article examines how prospective recognition from the US make other states more willing to act in accordance with the wishes of the high-status state. Through a plausibility probe of its interactions with both small, allied states, such as the Nordic states, and larger status-seeking powers like Russia, the analysis explores how recognition functions as a mechanism for converting status into power. The analysis also shows that recognition is less effective when the status gap is narrow, when recognition threatens core interests of the recognizer, and when expectations of the recognized state are unmet.

⁷¹ Ward, 'Status, stratified rights, and accommodation in IR'.

⁷² The US has been the most dominant state since the Second World War and should be conceived as a gatekeeper of the great power club. Recognition from the US thus represents a litmus test for great power status. See Røren, 'The belligerent bear', p. 23; Goh, 'Hierarchy and the role of the United States', pp. 360–1.

⁷³ De Carvalho and Neumann, 'Introduction', p. 11.

Killing for recognition: the Nordic states

The power of US recognition is best shown in its relationships with allied small and middle powers. The Nordic countries constitute one of the most adamant groups of small status-seekers.⁷⁴ The Nordic states seek status by trying ‘to be perceived as good, reliable partners in a hegemonic arrangement’.⁷⁵ One way in which the Nordics seek status is by joining US-led military coalitions; indeed, the Nordic small powers have gone to war alongside the US in places where they have no concrete interests and against groups and states which do not pose a threat to them.⁷⁶ Instead, recognition—primarily from the US—was their main goal. Even prior to assuming office as prime minister of Denmark in 2001, Anders Fogh Rasmussen said that he favoured ‘active participation in international military operations in order to give Denmark a stronger position on the international scene than its size warranted’.⁷⁷ He later cited Danish ‘visibility’ as the reason for its joining the US-led coalition in Afghanistan and Iraq.⁷⁸ Likewise, Norwegian defence bureaucrats worried that Norway’s status would drop in the eyes of the US and NATO allies, since it had not signalled a willingness to contribute militarily to *Operation Enduring Freedom*.⁷⁹ The political leadership concurred and sent troops. Defence minister Kristin Krohn Devold stated in an interview in 2010 that it was important to send troops early, due to the ‘signalling effect’ of relevancy it sent to the Americans.⁸⁰ Likewise, former foreign affairs minister Jan Petersen argued that by participating in coalition warfare, Norway ‘put something in which is good to have in our bank account’.⁸¹

Beyond motivation, Nordic military actions in US-led military coalitions were designed to maximize visibility and recognition from the US. Thus, the Nordic states did not just participate: they competed among themselves and sought to outshine others in the eyes of the Americans.⁸² Consequently, Norway and partic-

⁷⁴ Røren, ‘Status seeking in the friendly Nordic neighborhood’.

⁷⁵ De Carvalho and Neumann, ‘Introduction’, p. 15.

⁷⁶ Rasmus Brun Pedersen, ‘Bandwagon for status: changing patterns in the Nordic States status-seeking strategies’, *International Peacekeeping* 25: 2, 2018, pp. 217–41, <https://doi.org/10.1080/13533312.2017.1394792>; Rasmus Brun Pedersen, ‘Jumping on the bandwagon: status seeking as a driver for Sweden’s involvement in NATO-led operations’, *International Politics*, vol. 57, 2020, pp. 41–56, <https://doi.org/10.1057/s41311-019-00175-x>; Rasmus Brun Pedersen and Yf Reykers, ‘Show them the flag: status ambitions and recognition in small state coalition warfare’, *European Security* 29: 1, 2020, pp. 16–32, <https://doi.org/10.1080/09662839.2019.1678147>; Jakobsen, Ringsmose and Saxi, ‘Prestige-seeking small states’; Græger, ‘From “forces for good” to “forces for status”?’

⁷⁷ Quoted in Jakobsen, Ringsmose and Saxi, ‘Prestige-seeking small states’, p. 265.

⁷⁸ Jakobsen, Ringsmose and Saxi, ‘Prestige-seeking small states’, p. 265; Paul Beaumont, Lucas de Olivera Pais and Christiana Maglia, ‘Prestige and punishment: status symbols and the danger of white elephants’, *Cooperation and Conflict* 60: 1, 2024, <https://doi.org/10.1177/00108367241280178>.

⁷⁹ Bjørn Tore Godal et al., *En god alliert: Norge i Afghanistan 2001–2014* [A good ally: Norway in Afghanistan 2001–2014] (Oslo: Norwegian Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Ministry of Defence, 2016), p. 22, <https://www.regjeringen.no/contentassets/09faceca099c4b8bac85ca8495e12d2d/no/pdfs/nou201620160008000ddp-dfs.pdf>. (Unless otherwise noted at point of citation, all URLs cited in this article were accessible on 20 Feb. 2025.)

⁸⁰ John Inge Hammersmark, *Norske spesialstyrker fra skjult ressur til politisk spydspiss* [Norwegian special forces: from hidden asset to political spearhead] (Oslo: Norwegian Defence Command and Staff College, 2015), p. 71, <https://fhs.brage.unit.no/fhs-xmlui/bitstream/handle/11250/284450/MS3-15.pdf>.

⁸¹ Jakobsen, Ringsmose and Saxi, ‘Prestige-seeking small states’, p. 269.

⁸² For a similar dynamic in other policy fields, see Røren, ‘Status seeking in the friendly Nordic neighborhood’, p. 572; Wohlforth et al., ‘Moral authority and status in IR’, p. 534.

ularly Denmark were at times the largest contributor of troops per capita; they undertook the more dangerous tasks that no one else was willing to undertake, and were among only a handful of NATO members willing to drop bombs over Libya in 2011, Iraq in 2014–15 and Iraq/Syria in 2016.⁸³

The costs of US recognition of the Nordic states were low. The Nordic countries expected rewards in the form of ‘good will’ and ‘public recognition’, or some form of ‘credit in the bank’.⁸⁴ This included influence in NATO, and, particularly, access to policy-makers in Washington.⁸⁵ Some of these expectations were met, particularly for Denmark.⁸⁶ Fogh Rasmussen met regularly with US President George W. Bush; Danish diplomats entered closed US policy circles; and Danish military and intelligence branches received American assistance.⁸⁷ Moreover, with US backing, Fogh Rasmussen became secretary-general of NATO in 2009.⁸⁸ In 2014 he was succeeded in the latter role by former Norwegian Prime Minister Jens Stoltenberg.

There was little room for the US to mismanage recognition. However, President Barack Obama diluted the recognition to small and middle powers—including the Nordic countries—by suggesting they all ‘punch[ed] above their weight’.⁸⁹ Despite this, the Nordic states capitalized on the recognition politically. The commission of inquiry into the Afghanistan War established by the Norwegian government concluded in its evaluation report that it was more important for Norway ‘to be seen as a competent contributor in Washington, DC and in Brussels’ rather than to be assessed on the basis of its direct effects on the ground.⁹⁰ Likewise, Stoltenberg wrote in his 2016 memoir that, even though Norway’s participation in the NATO bombings of Libya in 2011 had economic and political costs, he knew that ‘the Norwegian effort made a strong impression on our allies: in NATO, in Washington, in Paris, and in London’.⁹¹ Similarly, successive Danish governments claimed that contributions to US-led coalitions succeeded because they were noticed, praised and respected by allies, especially the US.⁹² Some would argue that military involvement was a high price to pay for ceremonial acknowledgements and access to policy-makers in Washington. Yet, for our purposes, the status motives and justifications demonstrate how much potential recognition from the US matters for small and middle powers.⁹³

⁸³ Jakobsen, Ringsmose and Saxi, ‘Prestige-seeking small states’, pp. 266–7; Pedersen, ‘Bandwagon for status’, pp. 224–9.

⁸⁴ Jakobsen, Ringsmose and Saxi, ‘Prestige-seeking small states’, p. 262; Pedersen, ‘Bandwagon for status’, p. 218.

⁸⁵ Jakobsen, Ringsmose and Saxi, ‘Prestige-seeking small states’.

⁸⁶ Anders Henriksen and Jens Ringsmose, *Hvad fik Danmark ud af det? Irak, Afghanistan og forholdet til Washington* [What did Denmark get out of it? Iraq, Afghanistan and the relationship with Washington] (Copenhagen: Danish Institute for International Studies).

⁸⁷ Henriksen and Ringsmose, *What did Denmark get out of it?*

⁸⁸ Henriksen and Ringsmose, *What did Denmark get out of it?*, pp. 30–1.

⁸⁹ Joshua Keating, ‘Obama says every small country “punches above its weight”’, *Foreign Policy*, 3 March 2012, <https://foreignpolicy.com/2012/03/23/obama-says-every-small-country-punches-above-its-weight>.

⁹⁰ Godal et al., *A good ally*, p. 194, author’s translation.

⁹¹ Jens Stoltenberg, *Min historie* [My story] (Oslo: Gyldendal, 2016), p. 447, author’s translation.

⁹² Jakobsen, Ringsmose and Saxi, ‘Prestige-seeking small states’, pp. 267–8.

⁹³ This dynamic is also present outside the Nordic region. Canada acquired advanced fighter jets and provided a prolonged and sizeable military engagement in Afghanistan to gain recognition from the US. See Justin Massie and Benjamin Zyla, ‘Alliance value and status enhancement: Canada’s disproportionate military

Russia's rising power revisionism

Recognition from the US is also valuable for bigger states—in particular those who aspire to join the great power 'club'. Admission into the 'club' does not solely depend on the US, but recognition from the US is broadly conceived as a litmus test for great power status.⁹⁴ Thus a high-status state might seek status recognition from the US as the more highly positioned state.

During the Cold War, the Soviet Union (USSR) was considered a superpower of equal status to the US. But once the empire decayed and its status waned, both USSR and Russian leaders sought status from the Americans. US recognition incentivized beneficiary actions throughout the successive leaderships of Mikhail Gorbachev, Boris Yeltsin and Vladimir Putin. In pursuit of American recognition, Gorbachev worked more cooperatively with the US. He also gave up the fight to keep a unified Germany out of NATO and the right to govern in large territorial parts of the Soviet empire.⁹⁵ Here, potential US recognition as an equal helped Gorbachev to cooperate to a greater extent and adhere to the growing liberal international order.⁹⁶ The voluntary devolution of the Soviet empire and reduction in the USSR's aggressive posture aligned closely with US strategic objectives.

From 1991, Yeltsin's domestic reforms were accompanied by an urge to restore Russia's status.⁹⁷ The US spearheaded NATO expansion eastwards, meeting with vocal disapproval from Yeltsin. To salvage Russia's status, the US offered Russia membership in the Group of Seven (G7).⁹⁸ Yeltsin was not offended by the offer—in fact, his memoir suggests that he was quite proud to join the club.⁹⁹ The Russian president was willing to forgo what he had hoped would be the sphere of influence of the new Russia to be recognized as a member of the grouping, which consequently became the G8.

In his turn, Vladimir Putin was also tempted by US recognition. In the early days of the US-led 'war on terror' following the 9/11 attacks on US soil in September 2001, Russia entered a strategic partnership with the US. Russia shared intelligence, participated in search and rescue missions, and assisted the US with anti-Taliban measures in Afghanistan.¹⁰⁰ In 2009 President Obama began the New START¹⁰¹ negotiations, which Russia saw as recognition of its major power status. Among other things, Russia opened up new military air corridors for the US in the hope of gaining higher status. It relaxed its own position on

burden sharing in Afghanistan', *Politics & Policy* 46: 2, 2018, pp. 320–44, <https://doi.org/10.1111/polp.12247>.

⁹⁴ Goh, 'Hierarchy and the role of the United States', pp. 360–1; Røren, 'The belligerent bear', p. 23.

⁹⁵ Deborah Welch Larson and Alexei Shevchenko, 'Shortcut to greatness: the new thinking and the revolution in Soviet foreign policy', *International Organization* 57: 1, 2003, pp. 77–109 at pp. 100–2, <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0020818303571028>.

⁹⁶ Larson and Shevchenko, 'Shortcut to greatness'.

⁹⁷ Larson and Shevchenko, 'Russia says no', p. 272.

⁹⁸ Larson and Shevchenko, 'Russia says no', p. 272.

⁹⁹ Larson and Shevchenko, 'Status seekers', p. 80; Boris Yeltsin, *Boris Yeltsin: midnight diaries* (London: Weidenfeld & Nicolson, 2000), p. 131.

¹⁰⁰ Larson and Shevchenko, 'Russia says no', pp. 274.

¹⁰¹ Strategic Arms Reduction Treaty.

Baltic membership in NATO, allowed the US to store dismantled warheads and sanctioned Iran's nuclear programme.¹⁰²

The power of US recognition is thus visible in its relationship with major powers like Russia, yet its limits are equally visible. The type and scale of recognition that the US offered was unsatisfactory for Russia¹⁰³ and, as a consequence of the US' withholding recognition, Russia turned belligerent.¹⁰⁴ Russia's involvement in Syria, its war against Georgia, the Chechen wars and the annexation of Crimea, and the later full-scale war against Ukraine, are partly explained in the literature by a perceived status immobility from the Russian side.¹⁰⁵

The Russian case is not unique. States like China and Brazil have sought recognition from the US, and the US has benefited from this status-seeking. But the same countries have at some point acted in defiance of the US when their status-seeking has not been recognized. Just as with Russia, the 9/11 terrorist attacks on the US provided an opportunity for China to seek recognition from the US. China leveraged influence with Pakistan to encourage it to cooperate with the US in Afghanistan. China tracked wanted terrorists, shared intelligence and agreed to the establishment of an FBI office in Beijing.¹⁰⁶ Like Russia, China expressed the view that the recognition it received from the US was not enough.¹⁰⁷ Subsequently China sought to create alternative and competing institutions for global governance and has become more assertive in its own regional neighbourhood.¹⁰⁸

The status-seeking that Brazil has directed toward the US has been equally volatile. Brazil was the only South American state to participate in both world wars alongside the US, despite having no direct interests in either war.¹⁰⁹ It participated in the US intervention in the Dominican Republic in 1965 and broadly supported the US' interventions in central America. This solidified US dominance in the region.¹¹⁰ During the late 2000s, President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva was 'desperate

¹⁰² Larson and Shevchenko, 'Russia says no', pp. 275–6; Larson and Shevchenko, 'Status seekers', p. 89.

¹⁰³ Wolf, 'Taking interaction seriously', pp. 1201–4; Andrei P. Tsygankov, 'The frustrating partnership: honor, status, and emotions in Russia's discourses of the West', *Communist and Post-Communist Studies* 47: 3–4, 2014, pp. 345–54, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.postcomstud.2014.09.004>; Regina Heller, 'Russia's quest for respect in the international conflict management in Kosovo', *Communist and Post-Communist Studies* 47: 3–4, 2014, pp. 333–43, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.postcomstud.2014.09.001>.

¹⁰⁴ Wolf, 'Taking interaction seriously', pp. 1203.

¹⁰⁵ Larson and Shevchenko, 'Russia says no'; Maria Raquel Freire, 'The quest for status: how the interplay of power, ideas, and regime security shapes Russia's policy in the post-Soviet space', *International Politics*, vol. 56, 2019, pp. 795–809, <https://doi.org/10.1057/s41311-018-0164-y>; Elias Götz, 'Russia, the West, and the Ukraine crisis: three contending perspectives', *Contemporary Politics* 22: 3, 2016, pp. 249–66, <https://doi.org/10.1080/13569775.2016.1201313>.

¹⁰⁶ Larson and Shevchenko, 'Status seekers', p. 85.

¹⁰⁷ Sebastian Biba, 'It's status, stupid: explaining the underlying core problem in US–China relations', *Global Affairs* 2: 5, 2016, pp. 455–64 at p. 460, <https://doi.org/10.1080/23340460.2016.1276077>; Hanna Smith, 'Russia as a great power: status inconsistency and the two Chechen wars', *Communist and Post-Communist Studies* 47: 3–4, 2014, pp. 355–63, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.postcomstud.2014.09.005>.

¹⁰⁸ Biba, 'It's status, stupid'; William Ziyuan Wang, 'Destined for misperception? Status dilemma and the early origin of US–China antagonism', *Journal of Chinese Political Science*, vol. 24, 2019, pp. 49–65, <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11366-018-09596-6>; Tao Wenzhao and Xu Shengwei, 'The US factor in post-Cold War China–Russia relations', *International Politics*, publ. online 31 Jan. 2020, <https://doi.org/10.1057/s41311-020-00211-1>.

¹⁰⁹ Christina Stolte, *Brazil's Africa strategy: role conception and the drive for international status* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2015), p. 62.

¹¹⁰ Stolte, *Brazil's Africa strategy*, p. 61.

for recognition' from the US,¹¹¹ leading him to take on more regional and global responsibility and to play the role of guarantor of stability in South America.¹¹² But the alignment with the US has also 'yielded much frustration for Brazil'.¹¹³ Successive governments, particularly the Lula administrations, sought recognition by adopting a more confrontational stance towards the US. For example, Brazil did not support the US invasion of Iraq in the spring of 2003, criticized the US project of an American free trade area, institutionalized the BRICS group of countries (comprising Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa) as a counterweight to US dominance, and tried to foster regional integration that excluded the US.¹¹⁴

The potential and limits of US recognition

The US case demonstrates the fundamental dynamics of the power of recognition. First, the plausibility probe shows that recognition converts status into power. High-status states are able to persuade lower-status states to act according to the high-status states' interests without having to coerce them. In particular, the Nordic states have shown themselves as willing to kill for the prospect of US recognition. Some may reasonably point out that explanations are superfluous, given that the Nordic countries depend on the US for security status.¹¹⁵ However, there is no contradiction between seeking status and seeking security or shelter.¹¹⁶ As Mariager and Wivel put it, in the post-Cold War environment 'shelter seeking is conditioned upon status seeking, and status seeking is an important instrument for shelter seeking'.¹¹⁷

Second, the status gap between recognizer and status-seeker influences the power of recognition. The US' power of recognition also applies to rising powers like Russia. However, the rising powers were frustrated by the barriers for entry to the great power 'club'.¹¹⁸ Thus, instead of being helpful to the US, the rising powers turned to creative and competitive status-seeking. These approaches were not always beneficial, and were sometimes even harmful, to the US.¹¹⁹

Third, the US' relationship with the rising powers demonstrates the limits of US recognition. It also illustrates the agency that the US has in determining the kind of recognition it offers. For example, Russia had long wanted its own sphere

¹¹¹ Stolte, *Brazil's Africa strategy*, p. 67.

¹¹² Stolte, *Brazil's Africa strategy*, p. 67.

¹¹³ Stolte, *Brazil's Africa strategy*, p. 79.

¹¹⁴ Mario E. Carranza, 'Rising powers and international order: comparing Brazil and India's strategies for admission to the great power club', *Contemporary Security Policy* 38: 3, 2017, pp. 491–8, <https://doi.org/10.1080/13523260.2017.1351654>; Stolte, *Brazil's Africa strategy*, pp. 66–7.

¹¹⁵ See for example Jens Ringsmose, 'Paying for protection: Denmark's military expenditure during the Cold War', *Cooperation and Conflict* 44: 1, 2009, pp. 73–97, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0010836708099722>.

¹¹⁶ See Maria Mälksoo, 'Deterrence icons as status symbols: American forces in NATO's eastern flank', *Cooperation and Conflict* 60: 1, 2024, <https://doi.org/10.1177/00108367241254307>.

¹¹⁷ Rasmus Mølgaard Mariager and Anders Wivel, 'From Nordic peacekeeper to NATO peacemaker: Denmark's journey from semi-neutral to super ally', in Anne-Marie Brady and Baldur Thorhallsson, eds, *Small states and the new security environment* (Cham, Switzerland: Springer, 2021), pp. 103–118 at p. 113.

¹¹⁸ Larson and Shevchenko, 'Status seekers', p. 76.

¹¹⁹ Larson and Shevchenko, 'Status seekers', pp. 76–93.

of influence and a halt in NATO expansion in eastern Europe.¹²⁰ In other words, US recognition did not match Russia's expectations. In essence, Russia's status-seeking was misrecognized by the US. Misrecognition here does not refer to the idea that the US did not recognize an 'objectively' or morally legitimate claim that Russia had for great power status. Instead, it refers simply to the idea that Russia's self-image as a great power was not met by US recognition.¹²¹ The biggest reason for US misrecognition is the cost of recognition. Providing the kind of recognition that Russia wanted would position it as having an equal status to the US. This in turn would dilute the unique high status of the US. Moreover, offering spheres of influence and giving up the security of allies in central and eastern Europe is antithetical to US security interests and its allies.

Conclusion

In this article, I have developed a new understanding of how status converts into power in world politics. The power of status lies in the ability of high-status states to encourage beneficiary actions by others through recognition. These findings are consequential for future IR studies of status. This approach answers criticisms by MacDonald and Parent, as well as Mercer, that status is merely an illusion or chimera.¹²² The study stakes out a new research path that is methodologically and conceptually more tangible than the elusive concept of voluntary deference. The framework also provides an additional justification for the thriving research programme on social status and prestige in IR.

There are, however, important caveats to these findings. The broader empirical generalizability of this case-study is limited. Plausibility probes are used to modestly boost our confidence in theories, but they cannot be relied upon to test whether our assumptions are true in relation to how things work. Fully understanding the scope of the power of status would require research to study how recognition is employed by less unique and lower-status states. Indeed, the size of the status gap matters. It is not a certainty that small or middle powers can harness the same kind of power from recognition as the US.¹²³ Moreover, the plausibility probe has focused on the security relationship of the US *vis-à-vis* Russia and the Nordics. While status is omnipresent within world politics,¹²⁴ further research is needed to explore the policy limits of the theory.

With these caveats in mind, the theoretical framework developed above sets the stage for future studies of the power of recognition in world politics. The

¹²⁰ Maria Raquel Freire and Regina Heller, 'Russia's power politics in Ukraine and Syria: status-seeking between identity, opportunity and costs', *Europe-Asia Studies* 70: 8, 2018, pp. 1185–212 at p. 1189, <https://doi.org/10.1080/09668136.2018.1521914>.

¹²¹ Gustafsson, 'Recognising recognition through thick and thin', p. 259; Olga Malinova, 'Obsession with status and resentment: historical backgrounds of the Russian discursive identity construction', *Communist and Post-Communist Studies* 47: 3–4, 2014, pp. 291–303, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.postcomstud.2014.07.001>.

¹²² MacDonald and Parent, 'The status of status in world politics', p. 369; Mercer, 'The illusion of international prestige', pp. 134–5.

¹²³ William C. Wohlforth, 'Conclusion: a small middle power', in de Carvalho and Neumann, eds, *Small state status seeking*, pp. 146–55.

¹²⁴ Lebow, *Why nations fight*, p. 16; Beaumont, *The grammar of status competition*, p. 6.

framework lends itself well to a wide variety of analytical and methodological approaches. A broader and more comprehensive comparative case-study would reveal more aspects of the recognition mechanism than are identified here. Likewise, 'thicker' discursive analyses will provide a deeper understanding of how recognition is practised, bestowed or interpreted among actors. On the other side of the methodological spectrum, the theoretical framework opens up for more causal studies. For example, experimental designs could test whether introducing a treatment that offers potential recognition from high-status states increases respondents' willingness to undertake certain actions.